

To a Pangolin

NAUSHEEN EUSUF

Affection is an effort for the armored.
 No wonder, then, that the scaly pangolin
 inhabits an order by itself: the *pholidota*.
 But what if one dotes on such a thing?
 Foolish, no doubt. But I was unschooled
 in such matters, only a smitten amateur.
 Snout snug in a novel, you hardly noticed.
 When approached, you'd curl into a ball,
 aloof and inscrutable. What manners!
 Disgraceful. I couldn't tell head or tail.
 Piqued with a child's curiosity, I poked
 and prodded the queer little creature.
 Can armor defeat *amor* that conquers all?
 I was no more the enemy than an army
 of ants. I was unarmed, just enamored.
 So I waited—until it cautiously unrolled
 and met my gaze, disarmed and startled,
 my enchanting anteater, my doting *pholidota*.